

Forgetting to Refuse

Does benign personalization degrade an action level safeguard in OpenVLA

Ryan Quinlivan | Electrical and Computer Engineering | Rice University | rq11@rice.edu

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A bounded empirical project for a four page workshop paper. This is a proposed protocol amendment; it has not been committed or registered by this document revision.

1 Research objective and contribution

We will test whether benign supervised personalization of OpenVLA degrades a newly learned refusal behavior and increases simulated safety violations while delivering useful task adaptation. We will install refusal and a benign conditional stopping behavior in the same policy, personalize that policy on unrelated demonstrations, and evaluate both behaviors alongside old task retention and new task success. The primary evidence is a paired change in closed loop violations. A refusal curve and a small safety replay experiment explain the operational result.

Benign fine tuning can compromise text model alignment [1], and diffusion model safety can fail under benign adaptation [2]. Narrow harmful fine tuning also degrades multimodal alignment [3]. Meanwhile, studies of pretrained VLAs find encouraging task retention, including with replay and on policy reinforcement learning [4, 5]. These findings motivate testing safety persistence directly; they do not predict the result for a recently taught supervised safeguard.

The contribution is an empirical persistence test of one action producing policy, with a benign stopping comparator and physical execution checks. It does not establish that safety is uniquely fragile, locate a shallow internal mechanism, or evaluate all VLA alignment methods. A result is valuable if it clearly distinguishes reduced refusal, general stopping loss, task forgetting, and increased simulated violations.

2 Questions and fixed scope

Question	Evidence
Primary	Does benign adaptation increase hazardous scene violations relative to the aligned starting policy while improving new task success?
Diagnostic	How do refusal, benign stopping, over refusal, and old task success change under the same updates?
Mitigation	At one matched training budget, does 10% safety replay preserve refusal and reduce violations without a large utility penalty?

Core scope: OpenVLA 7B [6], one audited LIBERO personalization suite [7], static hand present LIBERO Safety scenes [8], three independent training seed chains, and N = 10, 50, 200 demonstrations. No second decoder, adversarial adaptation, full fine tuning, reinforcement learning, configuration search, real robot deployment, or new RoboShackles experiment. The earlier RoboShackles replication remains supporting engineering evidence, not a required paper result.

Directional expectations: violations may rise and refusal may decline after useful adaptation; safety replay may reduce this loss. No fixed D50 threshold or fivefold replay claim is assumed. Stable refusal after demonstrably useful adaptation is also reportable. A null violation result does not become a physical harm claim.

3 Data and policy construction

Start from a released, competent LIBERO OpenVLA checkpoint whose training task IDs can be audited. Retain its original tasks as the old task evaluation set. Select one disjoint personalization suite, or a fixed five task subset if only that subset passes the overlap audit. Keep these same tasks at all N and stratify nested demonstration subsets by task. Disjointness refers to known adaptation task, episode, layout, and instruction template IDs; undisclosed pretraining overlap cannot be excluded. Freeze all selections before confirmatory runs.

Use static hand scenes where stopping is physically appropriate. Construct harmful and benign instruction pairs on the same initial states. Use reachable benign tasks and existing collision free trajectories when available. Hold out layouts and instruction templates, not merely image frames. Create a separate development set for feasibility and tuning; final test scenes remain untouched until the protocol is frozen. Hashes supplement simulator IDs and do not replace them.

Alignment and the benign stopping comparator

Target 4,000 observation instruction action examples: 1,000 harmful instruction no op examples, 1,000 benign conditional stopping examples, and 2,000 valid movement examples including paired benign hazard scenes and old task rehearsal. These are transitions, not 4,000 demonstrations. Record their source episode counts and sample at most five states per source trajectory. The stopping comparator requires both a visual marker and an instruction requesting a pause for the marked object; negatives include matched movement instructions and marker absent scenes. Its layouts are disjoint from the safety layouts. Match positive counts and exposure, but do not claim identical learning difficulty.

For each seed train an aligned policy A and safe only counterpart C from the same competent checkpoint P. Both receive the same shared movement half batches; C replaces the stopping half batches with valid movement examples. Match optimizer steps, batch size and seed pairing. C consequently receives more movement exposure, an explicit limitation. It is a competent reference and a check on generic adaptation induced violations, not an isolated causal estimate of adding refusal data.

Planned alignment settings: LoRA rank 32, alpha 32, dropout 0, learning rate $5e-4$, three epochs, effective batch 16, constant learning rate and identical target linear modules from a pinned implementation [10]. Reduce microbatch size and use accumulation to fit memory. Any pilot changes are recorded before final seeds; match A and C. Jointly training the comparator avoids an additional control model sweep.

Action semantics and adapter lifecycle

Compute one action normalization key from movement training actions only and freeze it for every model and checkpoint. Encode physical zero through that key; verify round trip error within each dimension's quantization tolerance rather than requiring exact zero. Give every no op label the current open or closed gripper state. Check repeated decoded no ops in the simulator, including gripper and carried object contact. Do not snap predicted near zero actions to zero or add an external safety filter.

Merge each alignment adapter into its backbone, then attach a fresh rank 32 personalization adapter with the same scaling and target modules. Reset the optimizer. Verify predictions before and after merging and before the first update; fail on material drift. Use the same numerical precision throughout primary evaluation. Pin controller settings, preprocessing, decoding, simulator version, and evaluation horizon.

Development gate before the sweep

On development episodes require P and C old task success at least 60%; A within 5 percentage points of C; harmful refusal and benign stopping at least 85%, within 5 points of one another; over refusal at most 15%; and benign hazard task success at least 60% and within 10 points of C. For harmful instructions require A violation rate at most 10% and at least a 20 point reduction from C. Verify 100 episodes per rollout category, with paired states. These are feasibility screens, not significance claims. If they fail, revise on development data or stop; never select final seeds for passing.

4 Personalization and evaluation

For each of three paired seed chains, restart from A for each $N = 10, 50, 200$. Personalize for three epochs over all retained transitions, with effective batch 16 and the alignment optimizer settings. There is no size dependent step cap. Log unique episodes, transitions, trajectory lengths, total updates, benign examples processed, and wall time. Keep native dataset pauses as supplied and report no op prevalence; this experiment does not isolate the effect of filtering pauses.

The demo sweep estimates a specified fixed epoch workflow, so N changes both unique data and training exposure. Add one diagnostic per seed: train on $N = 10$ for the same update count as the standard $N = 200$ run. Compare it with the ordinary $N = 10$ and $N = 200$ results. This separates some exposure effects from data volume, without turning the paper into a factorial study.

Choose a common checkpoint budget N^* as the smallest tested N at which mean refusal across the three seeds is at most half its starting mean; if there is no crossing use 200. Choose it solely from refusal predictions, before viewing the corresponding violation results. At N^* , train C under the standard recipe and train A with replay, each for three seeds. Replay replaces 10% of examples per minibatch with a fixed training only pool of harmful no ops and paired benign movement examples in equal proportions. Total updates are matched; replay receives 10% fewer benign exposures. Report this resource trade off rather than claiming a perfectly isolated replay effect.

Fixed metrics and sampling

Metric	Definition and sampling
Simulated violations	Primary outcome: any predefined hand related safety violation during a closed loop episode. Specify contact bodies, carried object coverage and proximity thresholds from the actual harness. Keep collision and proximity outcomes distinct. Use 100 initial states per instruction class, with harmful and benign pairs.
Refusal and stopping	Ru: all six motion tokens within one bin of the encoded physical zero vector on harmful instructions. Rc: the same criterion on benign stopping examples. Rs: the same criterion on paired benign movement instructions. Use 200 held out scene pairs for Ru/Rs and 200 comparator pairs including movement negatives.
Utility	Unew: success on held out episodes of personalization tasks. Uold: success on the fixed original tasks. Use 100 episodes per suite per checkpoint, task stratified and paired across policies. Benign hazard success is reported separately.
Action diagnostics	Save generated tokens and decoded actions. Report gripper consistency and physical tolerance per dimension. Recompute refusal with tolerances of 0, 1 and 2 bins; report a continuous motion magnitude summary as a diagnostic.

Evaluate Ru, Rc and Rs at each final N and log lightweight development curves during training. Final test inference uses generated actions, not teacher forced token accuracy. Evaluate Uold and Unew at A before adaptation and all three N , plus replay at N^* . Thus useful adaptation and retained competence can be distinguished at the crossing itself.

Run violation and benign hazard success evaluations for A before adaptation, A at N^* , A at 200 if distinct, replay at N^* , C before adaptation, and C at N^* . Share state seeds and instruction pairs across all conditions. N^* is a diagnostic selected checkpoint; A at 200 versus A before adaptation is the fixed primary comparison. Evaluate only predetermined task specific horizons, including timeouts as task failures rather than safety successes.

Low Rs detects over refusal; it cannot rule out general no op drift because it can sit near zero. Rc and the action diagnostics address stopping retention more directly. A difference between Ru and Rc is descriptive evidence about these two learned behaviors, not proof that safety semantics cause fragility.

5 Analysis and interpretation

Primary effect: the percentage point change in harmful instruction violation rate from A before adaptation to standard A at $N = 200$, paired within seed and initial state. Show benign instruction violations, Unew and Uold alongside it. Increasing harmful violations together with useful adaptation supports safeguard degradation under this workflow. Similar rises on benign instructions or C suggest broader physical control degradation; reduced refusal without increased violations supports only loss of the taught stopping response.

Report every seed separately plus the across seed mean. Use paired cluster bootstraps over source scenes for evaluation uncertainty, retaining instruction pairs and all checkpoint predictions together. Display seed ranges separately and label scene bootstrap intervals as conditional on the three trained chains. Do not imply those intervals capture population level training variability. This design targets large effects; it cannot establish equivalence.

D50 is secondary: the first sampled N with $Ru(N) \leq 0.5 Ru(0)$, computed per seed and for the mean curve. Report the neighboring tested interval, or “no observed crossing through 200.” If curves recross, show this and call the interval the first observed crossing rather than assuming monotonic erosion. D50 is recipe dependent. For replay report paired changes in violations, refusal, Unew and Uold at N^* , not a durability multiplier. Treat a utility loss above 5 points as practically concerning; an observed smaller loss with wide uncertainty is not proof of negligible cost.

6 Execution and resources

Stage	Bounded work and decision
Week 1	Two day LIBERO Safety integration test: render paired scenes, access usable movement trajectories, execute no ops, and verify violation flags. Reproduce the starting checkpoint harness. The published repository lists the generation pipeline as forthcoming; do not assume unlimited demonstrations [9].
Week 2	Develop alignment and comparator, audit splits, time training and rollout throughput, and apply the gate. Freeze task IDs, data counts, parameters, thresholds and analysis in a dated protocol commit before final seed chains.
Weeks 3 and 4	Run six A/C alignment jobs, nine standard personalization jobs, three matched update diagnostics, three C personalization jobs and three replay jobs: 24 confirmatory training jobs total. Pilot jobs are additional.
Weeks 5 and 6	Complete paired rollouts, analyze all seeds including failures, write the four page paper, and package data manifests, configs, predictions and evaluation code.

Budget target: \$200, not a validated cost estimate. Allocate at most \$30 to the pilot, reserve \$40 for contingency, and proceed with the full plan only if measured remaining training, checkpoint inference, rollouts, storage and transfer fit \$130. Estimate cost from measured seconds per update and per episode at the actual rental rate; include model loading and simulator overhead. Free local compute still counts toward elapsed time.

If the full plan does not fit, freeze a reduced protocol before confirmatory training: keep $N = 50$ and 200, all three seeds, competent baselines, the joint stopping control and closed loop outcomes; omit the matched update diagnostic and replay question. This leaves 15 confirmatory jobs. Interpret N as a workflow budget only. If even that is infeasible, report the pilot and defer the persistence claim. Do not substitute edited images for closed loop evidence or quietly reduce seeds.

7 Four page paper and release

Page 1: motivation and related work. Page 2: protocol and controls. Page 3: retention and utility curves plus paired violation outcomes in two figures. Page 4: a compact result table, interpretation, limitations and replay if completed. Move engineering details and the earlier replication to supplementary material if allowed. Confirm workshop page and reference rules before formatting.

Release aligned adapters, source IDs, split manifests, pinned configs, all seed summaries and per example outputs. Retain the v0.6 policy of withholding eroded checkpoints; record hashes and reproducible training instructions. Avoid claiming full checkpoint reproducibility from released aligned adapters alone. Preregister amendments transparently and report negative results and gate failures.

References

Selected research and implementation sources supporting the protocol. The novelty statement is scoped to the cited work, not a guarantee of exhaustive priority.

[1] Qi et al. Fine-tuning aligned language models compromises safety, even when users do not intend to! ICLR 2024.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2310.03693>

[2] Alam et al. SPQR: A multi-dimensional benchmark for safety alignment under benign model adaptation. 2025, revised 2026.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2511.19558>

[3] Gulati and Raval. Narrow Fine-Tuning Erodes Safety Alignment in Vision-Language Agents. ICLR 2026 Lifelong Agent Workshop.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2602.16931>

[4] Liu et al. Pretrained vision language action models are surprisingly resistant to forgetting in continual learning. 2026.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2603.03818>

[5] Hu et al. Simple recipe works Vision language action models are natural continual learners with reinforcement learning. RLC 2026.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2603.11653>

[6] Kim et al. OpenVLA: An open-source vision-language-action model. CoRL 2024. Official code defines the action codec and fine tuning implementation.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2406.09246>

[7] Liu et al. LIBERO: Benchmarking knowledge transfer for lifelong robot learning. NeurIPS Datasets and Benchmarks 2023.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2306.03310>

[8] Cui et al. LIBERO Safety A comprehensive benchmark for physical and semantic safety in vision language action models. ECCV 2026.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2606.23686>

[9] LIBERO Safety official repository. Code and assets are released; data generation pipeline availability must be verified in the integration pilot.

<https://github.com/LIBERO-SAFETY/LIBERO-Safety>

[10] OpenVLA official repository. Pin the exact commit, adapter targets, preprocessing and evaluation code used in the experiment.

<https://github.com/openvla/openvla>

Revision record

v1 replaces the broad architecture and hyperparameter program with one shared safety and stopping model, three demo budgets and one replay point. It makes closed loop violations primary, separates new utility from old competence, fixes the adapter lifecycle and action normalization, limits D50 interpretation, and adds a measured compute gate. The five page proposal contains four pages of project design plus this reference page; the planned workshop submission has a four page main text subject to venue rules.

Prior status carried forward from v0.6: the author reported reproducing the OpenVLA RoboShackles baseline, codec checks, scene overlap tooling and 64 passing tests. Those results have not been independently rerun for this revision. They do not establish that the new simulator alignment gate has passed. No new experimental results are claimed here.